as for example when an Ajivika became the carrier of the news to a group of Buddhist monks that their teacher had attained ‘parinirvana’ (upon his death) in Kushinara. In this instance the Ajivika was shown holding a flower, the flower of the coral tree or ‘mandarava’, which he knew to be one that only grew in the world of gods or paradise, and which fell to earth only when a great and auspicious event had taken place.[35] As for relations between Ajivikas and Jainas, there is a similar play of cordiality and tension. The Jaina tradition alludes to the early friendship and association of Makkhali Goshala and Vardhamana Mahavira, the twenty-fourth Jaina ‘tirthankara’ (teacher of the path of liberation). Matters between the two sects, though, became much less cordial following a couple of conversions of Ajivikas to the Jaina faith.[36]

That all these sects were looking to expand their following and were thus competing for converts and adherents will have been an important reason for the rivalries among them. Another reason may well have been the competition for royal patronage. Like the Buddha and his followers, Makkhali Goshala was a name known in the royal circles of Magadha. During the Buddha’s lifetime, we learn that ministers in the court of Ajatashatru, the king of Magadha, suggested the names of six teachers, one of whom was Goshala, as having the capacity to resolve the king’s doubts. So, along with various other sects, the kings of Magadha were patrons of the Ajivikas as far back as the sixth century BCE. Later, such ascetics are shown exercising considerable influence in the court of the Maurya dynasty. This is obvious from the ease with which they move in and out of royal company in the varying versions of the story that link Ashoka’s mother with an Ajivika.

Let us look at the prediction itself. Actually, the prophecy about Ashoka’s future as told by the Ajivika unfolds varyingly, depending upon the text. One version—the one which has been recounted—takes the prediction back to the time when Ashoka was a young man. Another